Use of Mobile Phones / Social Media Policy

Policy Title: Use of Mobile Phones / Social Media Policy

Effective Date: [Insert Date]

Review Date: [Insert Date – usually annually]

Version: 1.0

Applies to: All staff, contractors, volunteers, residents, and visitors at [INSERT CARE HOME NAME]

1. Policy Statement

At [INSERT CARE HOME NAME], we recognise that mobile phones and social media are part of everyday life. However, their use within the care home must be carefully managed to ensure:

- The privacy, dignity, and safety of residents is maintained at all times
- Confidential and sensitive information is protected
- Professional boundaries are upheld
- The reputation of the care home is safeguarded

We are committed to promoting safe and responsible use of mobile phones and social media.

2. Purpose

This policy provides guidance on:

- Appropriate and inappropriate use of mobile phones within the care home
- Professional standards relating to social media use
- Safeguards to protect residents, staff, and the organisation from harm

3. Scope

This policy applies to:

- All staff (permanent, agency, and volunteers)
- Residents and their families/visitors
- Contractors working on site

4. Roles and Responsibilities

Registered Manager:

- Ensures staff are aware of and adhere to this policy
- Investigates breaches and takes appropriate action
- Provides guidance and training on safe mobile phone and social media use

All Staff:

- Use mobile phones responsibly and in line with this policy
- Never share or post any confidential or identifying resident information online
- Report any inappropriate use of mobile phones or social media

Visitors and Residents:

- Are expected to respect residents' and staff privacy when using mobile phones or social media within the home
- Must not take photographs or recordings of other residents without consent

5. Mobile Phone Use

5.1 Staff

- Personal mobile phones must not be used during working hours except on authorised breaks and in designated areas.
- Mobile phones must not be taken into resident care areas or used while providing care.
- Work-related calls or messages must only be made using authorised devices.

5.2 Residents and Visitors

- Residents may use personal mobile phones, provided it does not impact their wellbeing or others.
- Visitors must avoid disturbing residents or staff with phone use.
- Taking photographs or videos of residents, staff, or the care home environment requires prior consent.

6. Social Media Use

6.1 Professional Standards

- Staff must never share, post, or discuss any confidential information relating to residents, colleagues, or the care home on social media.
- Posting images or content that could damage the reputation of the care home is strictly prohibited.
- Staff must not identify themselves as representatives of the care home on personal accounts unless authorised.

6.2 Residents and Families

- Residents and relatives are free to use social media but must respect the privacy of others.
- Any concerns about online content relating to the home should be reported to management.

7. Confidentiality and Safeguarding

- The use of mobile phones or social media to share personal or sensitive information without consent is a serious breach of confidentiality and safeguarding.
- Breaches may result in disciplinary action, safeguarding referrals, or legal action.

8. Training and Awareness

- All staff will receive training on confidentiality, data protection, and appropriate use of mobile phones/social media.

- Staff will be reminded regularly of their responsibilities through supervision and team meetings.

9. Monitoring and Enforcement

- The Registered Manager reserves the right to monitor compliance with this policy.
- Any breach will be investigated and may lead to disciplinary action in line with the staff code of conduct.

10. References

- Data Protection Act 2018 / UK GDPR
- Health and Social Care Act 2008 (Regulated Activities) Regulations 2014
- CQC Fundamental Standards – Regulation 10 (Dignity and Respect), Regulation 12 (Safe Care and Treatment)
- NMC / HCPC Codes of Professional Conduct (if applicable)

11. Related Policies

- Confidentiality / GDPR Policy
- Privacy and Dignity Policy
- Safeguarding Adults Policy
- Whistleblowing Policy
- Disciplinary Policy

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